

***A Peek Into A
Kodava Wedding***

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May 4th and 5th, 2024

An Introduction

A Kodava wedding is a delightful blend of joy and solemnity, showcasing unique customs and traditions. It is a fun-filled and colourful affair with much feasting and dancing.

What surprises visitors from outside Coorg is the absence of priests and rituals that solemnise a typical Hindu wedding. Instead, prayers are offered to ancestors at the sacred lamp and the wedding ceremony is guided by elders whose blessings are sought. The blessings of our ancestors are paramount to us.

May 4th Evening: Oorkuduva Ceremony

Oorkuduva literally means the day when the villagers, close relatives and well wishers get together to help with the wedding preparations.

On the Oorkuduva evening it is customary to begin the ceremonies by invoking the blessings of our Goddess Kaveri and Lord Iguthappa by performing a very simple ritual of lighting the Thookbolcha (traditional Coorg oil lamp).

This is followed by putting a Pavala Maale (coral chain) and Pathak (which to us is like a mangalsuthra) to the bride by her mother.

May 5th Early Morning: Balle Udo

(Bangle Ceremony)

On the morning of the wedding a bangle lady from the village puts odd number of black and red glass bangles on the bride's hands. As a counterpart to this ritual the groom gets his nails cut and a shave by the barber. After the ritual bath, the close relatives dress up the bride and groom for the wedding festivities to begin.

The bride wears a sari with a long sleeved blouse, a red veil and is adorned in traditional Coorg jewellery. The groom on the other hand wears a White Kupya (long coat) tied with a red and gold Chele (sash) into which in front a Peechekathi (dagger) and at the back an Odikathi (sword) are tucked.

May 5th Morning: Single Muhurtha

The bride is blessed by guests in a traditional way by sprinkling rice over her head and giving her milk from a little silver pot while bestowing gifts.

At first, they are blessed by their parents, followed by close relatives and other guests.

May 5th Early Evening: Baale Kethuva Ceremony

(Cutting Of The Banana Stumps)

At the entrance an odd number of plantain trunks are pegged to the ground. One of the close elder relative of the groom's party who is designated for the task observes the formalities and comes forward. He walks three times around the plantain trunks, makes a short gesture of prayer and proceeds to cut each plantain stump with a single oblique stroke of the sword. He celebrates the completion of the task by dancing a jig to the lively Valaga (traditional Coorg music). Similarly a relative of the bride's party also cuts a set of plantain stumps.

This ceremony is supposed to signify the strength and chivalry of the men folk.

Dampathi Muhurtha

The groom is escorted to the mantap accompanied by his Bojakara (best man), two girls carrying lamps (equivalent to flower girls), Valaga and close relatives. The bride is escorted next, in a similar way with her Bojakarthi (equivalent to the maid of honour). At the mantap the bride and groom first offer prayers and then go around the mukkali (three legged stool) thrice. Before sitting down they put their right foot three times across the mukkali. The three legs of the mukkali stand for the Holy Trinity of Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva. The bride and groom invoke their blessings as they now become a married couple.

Garlands are exchanged and the Sammanda Adakuva ceremony (formal dialogue between the elders) legalises the marriage. The couple are then blessed by their close relatives and are given Cheela Pana (small red bag, filled with gold and other coins) as a symbol of prosperity. Then the rest of the guests gathered take turns to bless the bride and groom individually. The couple touch the feet of elders for blessings.

Batte Thadapa Ceremony:

(Barring The Bride From Leaving Her Home)

According to Kodava custom the first right to marry the bride is that of her maternal uncle's son or her paternal aunt's son. So adding to the festivities, is this fun-filled custom where the bride's cousin stops her from leaving saying that she was promised in marriage to him. After much hilarious arguing and bargaining, the cousin lets her go by settling for a gold coin and a bottle of fine whiskey. The coin is then tied to the hem of the bride's veil and the cousin sends the bride off by declaring her as a beloved sister from now on.

May 5th Evening: Ganga Pooja

After the Muhurtha, the bride is taken to the groom's house where the Ganga Pooja takes place. The bride is then led to the well by the groom's mother where she offers a simple prayer and breaks a coconut with the groom's Peechekathi (dagger). She then has to carry two pots of water on her head, accompanied by two girls from the groom's family. While carrying the water into her new home, the members of the groom's family playfully obstruct the bride by dancing in front of her for a couple of hours.

This ritual is supposed to test the bride's endurance and patience and also symbolises the commencement of the bride's duties in the groom's house.

This ceremony concludes the festivities of the wedding celebrations!

*Thank You For Coming & Hope Y'all Have A
Blast!*